

headphones are the culprits rather than the device itself. The only redeemer for them is the SGH-E840, which offers decent call reception and acceptable music quality.

Coming to the camera quality, let's face it—none of these devices have cameras worth anything more than a cursory shot. Samsung's SGH-X820 and SGH-E840 offer the best cameras in the sub-12.5 grand block. Since none of these phones have a lot of applications installed, they're all reasonably fast.

Our Conclusion

If you're looking for a good phone in this category, Nokia's 6300 will satisfy at Rs 11,489. Its overall dominance in our tests, and signal quality in particular aside from the solid build, make it one of the candidates for our *Digit* Best Buy Gold award.

However, this was a close affair: the Samsung SGH-E840 was neck and neck all the way, with the 6300 just sneaking ahead by a hairsbreadth. Samsung's E840 shares the precious yellow with Nokia—joint Best Buy Gold. These phones are very different, however—the Samsung should be your choice if you want a slick-looking phone with a decent camera; just 10,700 rupees.

If you want a cool-looking clamshell phone, the Motorola KRZR K1 is for you. At under Rs 10,000, and with great build quality, a flashy keypad, and a body that will get onlookers all hot and envious, this is a good phone for college-goers who want something compact and curvaceous.

Dare To Flash (Rs 12,501 To Rs 20,000)

Features

Motorola is the only brand to have featured a touchscreen phone in this price category. The **ROKR E6** uses Tux mobile (Linux), similar to

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Samsung SGH-E840
Slick Slider

the Motomring (the A1200). Neither phone had any sort of a number keypad, a glaring omission in our opinion. Just try typing with an on-screen keypad and a stylus and you'll understand why. The typing area on-screen is also limited to a small patch where letters are detected. Also, only characters can be detected, not entire words (Windows Mobile does that). These gripes aside, it's a brave effort from Motorola—touchscreen phones rarely cost under Rs 20,000.

Last year's winner, the **N70**, quickly gets overshadowed. The **5700 Xpress Music** is a quality offering from Nokia featuring a twist keypad similar to the one on the **Nokia 3250**. The other side of the keypad has dedicated music keys.

The best-looking phone in this comparison (this writer's personal choice!) is the **Sony Ericsson K790i**. An exquisite matte-finished rear (some soft-feeling surface coating) contrasts well with the piano black finish on the front. The bezel surrounding the screen is brushed metal, again black. A good keypad and a joystick smooth as butter makes working with this phone a delight. The ultra-crisp screen and high-resolution icons are other attractions. While on topic, how does a 3.2 MP camera with an ultra-bright Xenon flash sound?

The **SE W880i** is the slimmest phone in this category. Surprisingly usable, though—the buttons are tiny and good for similar fingers. The joypad looks painful at first but works well. The **W610i** has an even smaller keypad that is uncomfortable if you're using your fingertips: the trick is to use your nails. The circular menu buttons don't offer feedback and you need to press at a particular place to get the desired key hit, else it might not register. The older W810i is still around—decent keypad, and a crisp-looking, small screen.

Nokia Sirocco 8800 Gold Edition: Of Luxuries And Sinful Indulgences!

So you've got the cash to burn, but being the self-made millionaire that you are, spending upward of 5 lakhs on a Vertu seems criminal. Enter the 8800 Sirocco and Nokia's upmarket offering, for those who delineate the term *upwardly mobile*. A beautiful box, well designed accessories, and a phone whose body is glossy steel that will shimmer when exposed to light will greet you. You immediately get a feeling of cash well-spent (though we can't afford to test this parameter!). Remember to have your valet carry around chamois leather with him—the surface of this phone is a smudge magnet.

The display is scratch-resistant sapphire glass. You won't think much of the display itself once you see the N95 (256K colours and 208 x 208 pixels doesn't seem much in comparison), but who gives a hoot about the screen when you probably have PAs to do all your dirty work, right? That said, the display is crisp in its own right, owing to its smaller size. Two batteries are provided, and so is a neat-looking charging dock that can charge your phone and the spare battery simultaneously.

The 8800 has an unbeatable slider (quality- and ergonomics-wise) that we initially had no clue how to operate. Pushing

downward on the keypad recess to reveal the keypad does nothing and we thought, "Oi, what's up here!" Instead, you have to push upward on the silver-coloured protrusion. Voila!

The display and keypad slide out together. Engaging is a very decisive metal click. We must have done this at least 200 times on the phone—absolutely no give in the mechanism, superb!

The 8800 Sirocco has 128 MB of memory onboard with no expansion. Music quality is good; however, with a paltry amount of storage, you're never going to ditch your PMP. The camera is strictly decent—more for show than anything. Incidentally, the lack of a POP port (ugly things those!) means you will be solely reliant on Bluetooth for data syncing. Best leave that task to your PA.

The 8800 Sirocco, true to its pedigree, is all about class and less about functionality. It's a full fledged phone and gives you the added functionality of a camera and a music player. This is not where the charm lies in though—simply carrying around a Sirocco is bound to get you a lot of attention! Think of more as a fashion accessory and an essential part of your designer wardrobe! At rupees 65,000 it'll bring out the latent class in that Armani (while ensuring your PA stays busy!).

